Volume I · No. 1

— A PRIVATE READING —

Three Poems

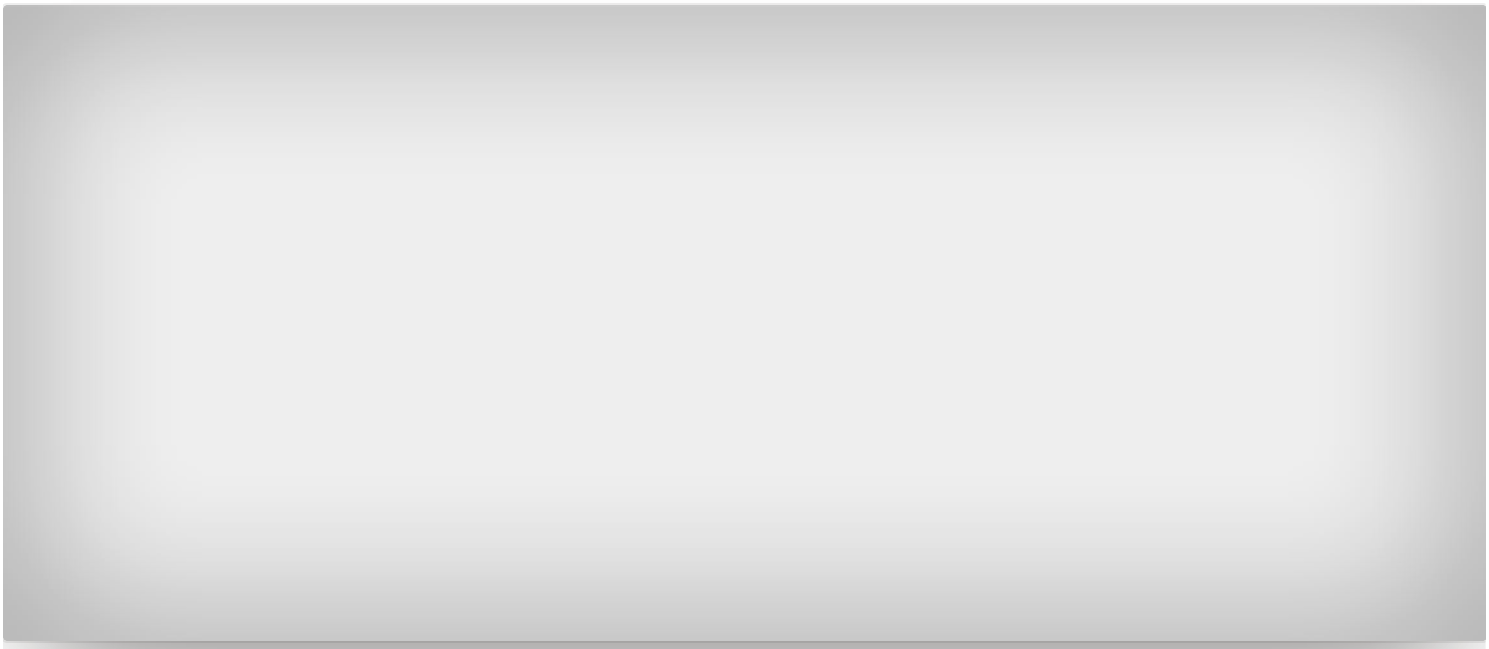
by **Carlos E. Cortés**

A first visual reading, set to original footage. For Dr. Cortés's eyes, with deep gratitude for the words.

Poem I

Breakfast in Sun City

August 20, 2014 · from Fourth Quarter



A morning in a diner. Two generations, one table.

Breakfast in Sun City
It's family time again
People coming from all over
Get together because then

They can spend some time with Grandma
Meet at Coco's right at nine
Have an omelet or a burger
Cup of coffee would be fine

At last I get a table
To watch the world go round

The mix of generations
From some tables, not a sound

A senior staring into space
A grandkid at his phone
No need for conversation
Just people on their own

It's lovely to see families
Get together now and then
That man's waiting for his daughter
Oh, she'll get here, not sure when

But she sure won't hold her smartphone
And everyone will see
That she smiles and talks and listens
While he tells her of the tree

That's just about to blossom
And the grass that's growing tall
He's sure he'll think of something else
If not, that will be all

Until the time, a month from now,
When she drives down again
To tell him that she loves him
And will surely ask him when

He's coming up to visit her
So they can have more time

They've got so much to talk about
While he's still in his prime

Of eighty years of living
Of eighty years of thought
Of eighty years of wisdom
Of things that can be taught

To all of his grandchildren
Who can learn so much for free
So much that can't be paid for
They'll listen at his knee

Of course the kids are eager
But fiddle with their caps
And even as he talks to them
They're busy checking apps

I'm glad that I was different
When with my family
And even as the years went by
I showed how much I cared

Then Granddad went, so Grandma
Lived alone amid their stuff
They'd saved and stored for decades
There was certainly enough

For her to tell me stories
I'd heard so many times

I feigned pure fascination
That's surely not a crime

One day when she was ninety-three
When saying our goodbyes
“Next time we'll go through photographs”
She looked into my eyes

But they came two days later
Paramedics took her in
She was gone before I reached her side
That's surely not a sin

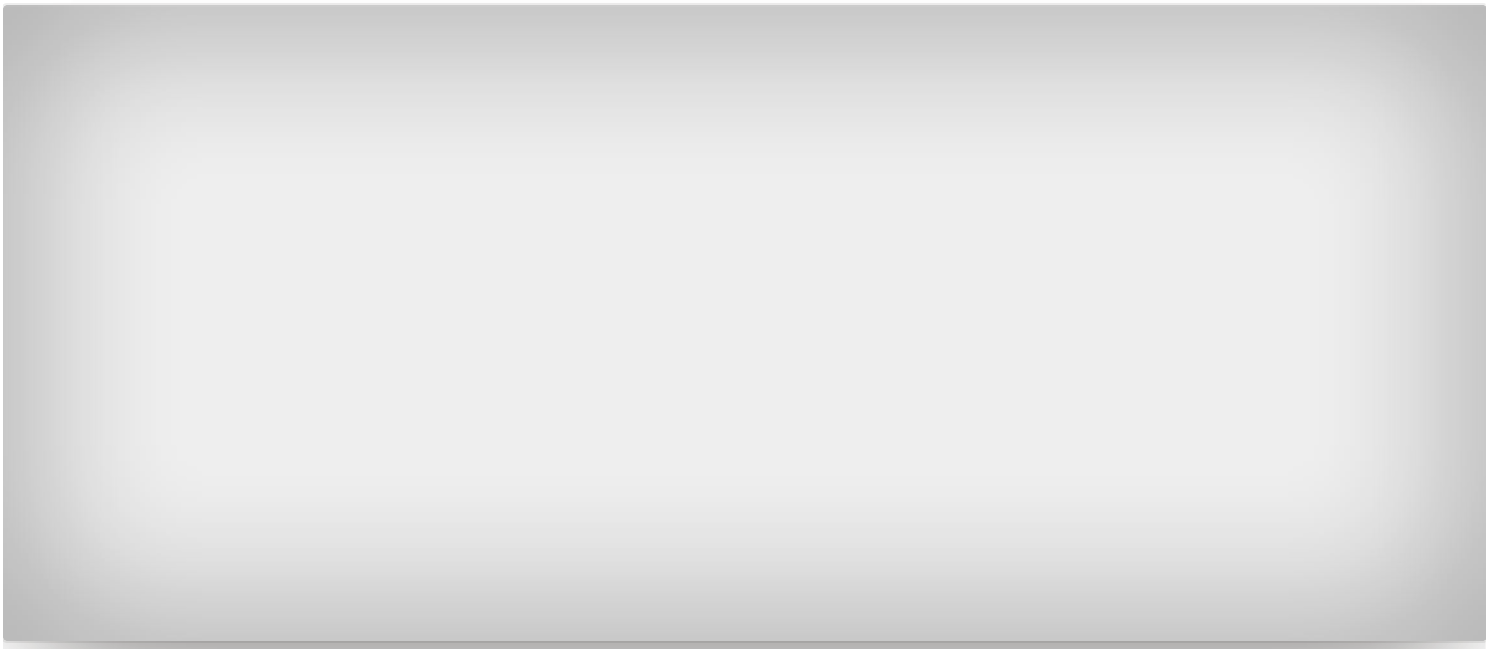
I'm glad we talked so often
I'm glad we talked so long
I'm glad I listened carefully
I'm glad I heard her song

I looked around the restaurant
And as I watched, I knew
I'd been a caring grandson
At least I think that's true

Poem II

Obligations of the Last Man Standing

from Tenth Decade · 2026



Candlelight. A ledger of lives. The keeper of stories.

Time passes
Life moves on
Then it ends
At least for others
But not for me
Not just yet
At 92

So when others depart
I'm left to tell their stories
When their families
hold celebrations of life

When people show up wondering
How was it way back then

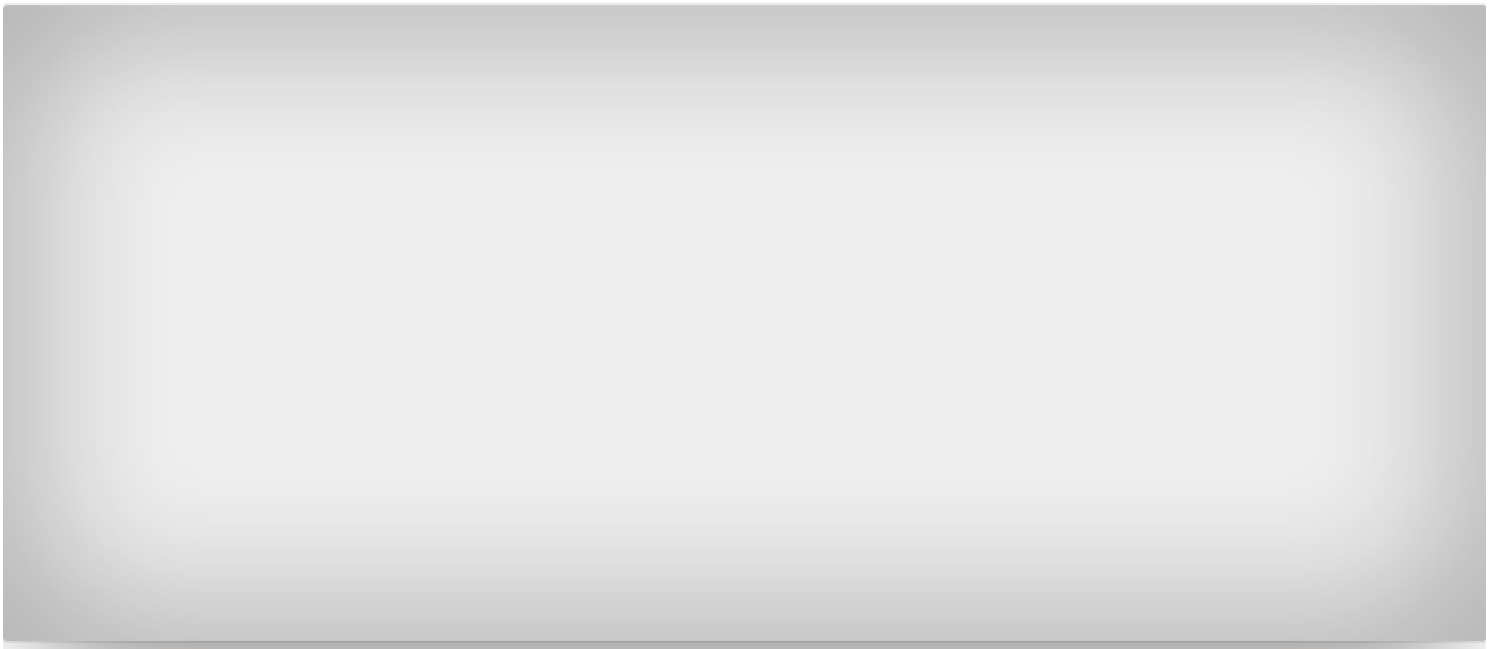
Stories that I remember
Or try to recall
Stories that I massage
To make families happier
Stories that I invent
To become part of their legend
Stories that I hope are true
Because they're based on faulty memory
Because everyone's memory is faulty

That's the role I play
That's the role I was destined to play
Simply because
I'm the last man standing
And people turn to me
To tell them what it was like

Poem III

Tomorrow

from Tenth Decade · 2026



A predawn room. One more sunrise. Still smiling.

Tomorrow and tomorrow and tomorrow
Recede relentlessly
From an assumption
Into an expectation
Followed by

Hope
Concern
Fear
And then resignation

But finally,
if all goes well,

a return to the ordinary pleasures
Of reminiscing about having led
A pretty good life

And finally the unexpected jubilation
Of the sun coming up
One last time
With my loved one's
Glorious face on the pillow
Next to me
Still smiling

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Videos by Charles Martin · A prototype in private review

Seedance footage and ElevenLabs narration in progress. Replace video sources as renders complete.